MICHIGAN

The Great Lakes State



In the mid-1800s, a remarkable migration quietly reshaped the rugged Upper Peninsula of Michigan. Copper had been discovered beneath the ancient rock of the Keweenaw Peninsula, and mining companies were desperate for experienced men to pull it out. They found them in Cornwall, England—a windswept peninsula on Britain's southwestern tip where generations of men had worked deep, dangerous tin and copper mines since the Roman era. The Cornish knew hard rock mining the way sailors know the sea, and by the 1860s and 1870s, thousands of them had crossed the Atlantic and settled in towns like Calumet, Hancock, and Houghton, drawn by steady wages and the familiar pull of ore beneath their boots.

They brought their families, their Methodist chapels, their wrestling traditions—and they brought their pasties.

The Cornish pasty was never fancy. It was working food, engineered by the wives and mothers of Cornwall to survive a full shift underground. A thick rope of crimped pastry sealed beef, potato, turnip, and onion inside a sturdy crust that could be carried in a coat pocket and eaten without utensils in the dark. The thick crimped edge served as a handle, allowing miners—whose hands were often dirty with arsenic-laced dust—to eat the filling and discard the crust entirely. Some miners even believed their pasties should be marked with their initials at one end, so that if a portion was set aside mid-shift, no man would accidentally eat another's lunch.

In the Keweenaw, the tradition took root as deeply as the copper itself. Cornish women—practical, resourceful, and fiercely proud of their cooking—adapted the recipe to what was available in Michigan's north country. Local rutabaga became a reliable substitute for the turnip used back home. Some families added a pinch of this, adjusted a seasoning there, and over time the Michigan pasty developed its own subtle regional identity, distinct enough that debates about the "correct" filling became a proud local tradition that continues to this day.

By the early 1900s, Calumet had become one of the wealthiest communities per capita in the United States, its streets lined with opera houses, hotels, and merchant shops—all fueled by copper money and immigrant labor. The pasty fed the men who built it. Sold from home kitchens, church basements, and eventually small shops and roadside stands, it moved beyond the Cornish community and became the everyday food of Finnish, Croatian, Italian, and Slovenian miners as well, each culture quietly adopting it as their own. Today, hand-lettered pasty shop signs still dot the Upper Peninsula highway, and no visit to the U.P. is considered complete without one.

When you crimp the edges of your own pasty and slide it into the oven, you are participating in something that stretches back through Michigan winters and Cornish moors alike—a simple, honest meal that has fed hard-working people for nearly two centuries. The crust will puff and brown, the filling will turn fragrant and tender, and when you pull it apart you'll understand immediately why generations of miners tucked one in their pocket every morning without a second thought. Some foods earn their place in a culture. The pasty didn't just earn it—it mined it.

MICHIGAN-STYLE CORNISH PASTY

Bite into a Cornish Pasty and let the golden, crimped crust give way to a steaming rush of tender beef, sweet turnip, and earthy potato—humble ingredients wrapped in pastry that has warmed the hands and hearts of miners, farmers, and wanderers for centuries.

Yield: 6 pasties

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INGREDIENTS

DOUGH

- 3 cups all-purpose flour
- 1 tsp salt
- ½ cup lard, cold and cubed
- ¼ cup unsalted butter, cold and cubed
- ½ cup cold water (more if needed)

FILLING

- 1 lb. beef skirt steak or chuck, cubed (or you can use a mix of beef and pork)
- 2 medium potatoes, peeled and diced
- 1 cup rutabaga, peeled and diced (optional but traditional)
- 1 medium onion, chopped
- 1 ½ tsp salt
- ¾ tsp black pepper
- ½ tsp thyme
- ½ tsp sage
- ¼ tsp allspice (optional, adds a bit of warmth)

TO ASSEMBLE

- 3 Tbsp butter
- 1 egg, beaten with 1 Tbsp water

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Preheat and prep*: Adjust the oven rack to the middle position and preheat to 375˚F (190˚C). Line a rimmed baking sheet with parchment.
2. *Prepare the Dough*: In a large bowl, combine the flour and salt. Add the lard and butter to the flour mixture. Use a pastry cutter, fork, or your fingers to work the fat into the flour until the mixture resembles coarse crumbs. Gradually add the cold water, stirring until the dough begins to come together. Add more water as needed, just until the dough holds together but is not too sticky. Wrap the dough in plastic wrap and refrigerate for 30 minutes while you prepare the filling.
3. *Prepare the Filling*: In a large bowl, combine the diced beef, potato, rutabaga, and onion. Keeping everything in a small, even dice is the traditional way—it lets the raw filling cook through in the same time the crust takes to bake. Add seasonings and toss until evenly distributed. Keep the filling cold until you're ready to fill.
4. *Assemble the Pasties*: On a lightly floured surface, roll each disk of dough into a circle about 8-inch across and ⅛-inch thick. Don't roll it too thin, or the juices will break through as it bakes.

5. *Fill and crimp*: Mound about 1 heaping cup of filling onto one half of each round, leaving a 1-inch border, and dot the top with ½ Tbsp of the butter. Brush the border lightly with water, fold the empty half over the filling to meet the edges, and press firmly to seal. Crimp the seam by folding it over itself in a rope pattern, or press with the tines of a fork—the crimp should sit along the top edge, the classic pasty seam. Cut two small vents in the top of each.
6. *Wash and bake*: Arrange the pasties on the prepared sheet and brush all over with the egg wash. Bake for 45–50 minutes, until deep golden brown and firm. To check doneness, slip a thin knife through a vent—the potato and rutabaga should be tender. If the tops brown too quickly, tent loosely with foil for the last 10 minutes.
7. *Rest and serve*: Let the pasties cool on the pan for at least 15 minutes before eating—the filling holds tremendous heat straight from the oven, and a short rest lets the juices settle. Serve warm, with your favorite side dishes like coleslaw, pickles, or a light salad.

